International Labour Organization

How to support an employer?

Manual for managerial and operational teams in Public Employment Services

A guide to the collection: "Building my Future at Work"

How to support an employer?

Manual for managerial and operational teams
in Public Employment Services

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▶ Foreword

In a global environment marked by economic uncertainty, technological changes, ecological transition and profound transformations in societal expectations, labour markets are facing unprecedented challenges. In order to address these issues, the role of the Public Employment Services (PES) is constantly being strengthened, as key players in regulating the labour market, promoting decent work and facilitating career transitions.

For more than seventy-five years, Convention No. 88 of the International Labour Organisation has defined the fundamental missions of the PES and reiterated their essential responsibility: to contribute to effective intermediation between the supply and demand for employment, with the aim of achieving full employment, equity and social justice. This mission implies an active commitment not only to jobseekers, but also to employers, who are strategic partners in the smooth running of the labour market.

This guide fully embraces this vision. It aims to support the PES in strengthening their relationship with employers, be they public or private, national or local, large groups or small businesses. It provides an in-depth analysis of the current obstacles to this cooperation, highlights the specific expectations of businesses, and offers operational guidelines for building a tailored, clear and effective service offering.

The guide is also intended to help modernise practices, through better segmentation of target audiences, strategic use of digital tools, proactive talent management and more assertive positioning of the PES as a credible and reliable HR partner. In particular, it stresses the need to restore trust, improve the visibility of the services on offer, and develop a sustainable partnership approach with the business world.

By bringing together observations from the field, normative references, feedback from experience and practical tools, this study offers employment professionals a structured and evolving framework to support the dynamics of change and respond more effectively to employers' needs. It reflects the shared conviction that fostering renewed dialogue between the PES and businesses is an essential condition for building more resilient, inclusive and sustainable labour markets.

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▶ Introduction

On the ground, Public Employment Service (PES) professionals see it every day: while jobseekers inherently walk through the doors of agencies, employers are less present. Too few companies turn to public services when recruiting. This observation, which is shared by many countries, slows down intermediation and limits the impact of employment policies.

But without job offers, how can we effectively support jobseekers? Without structured dialogue with businesses, how can we anticipate needs in terms of skills, adapt training, guide jobseekers and respond to recruitment pressures? Strengthening the relationship with employers is therefore not an option. It is essential if the PES is to fulfil its general interest role.

This guide has been designed to satisfy this need. It offers those involved in the PES concrete benchmarks, operational tools and tried-and-tested strategies for building a lasting relationship of trust with employers. It explores the specific expectations of businesses, the persistent obstacles to using public services, the particularities of the "hidden market" in recruitment, and the levers for action that can be mobilised.

The reality of the labour market requires us to move away from standardised strategies. The diversity of employers, the multiplicity of recruitment channels and regional or sectoral disparities call for some tailored responses. That's why this guide also highlights innovative practices, segmentation strategies, digital tools and partnership initiatives that enable PES to adapt, convince and make a difference.

This guide is aimed at employment professionals and public decision-makers, to shed light on the challenges of modernised intermediation, centred on listening, adapting and co-constructing solutions. It is based on clear observations: the predominance of the hidden market in recruitment practices, the lack of knowledge or persistent mistrust of public services, but also on inspiring examples of successful cooperation between the PES and the business world.

By strengthening their ability to understand the needs of businesses, anticipate changes in the labour market and offer appropriate services, the PES can become the HR partners of choice, as well as for those who are most alienated from the employment market. This guide aims to contribute to this ambition.

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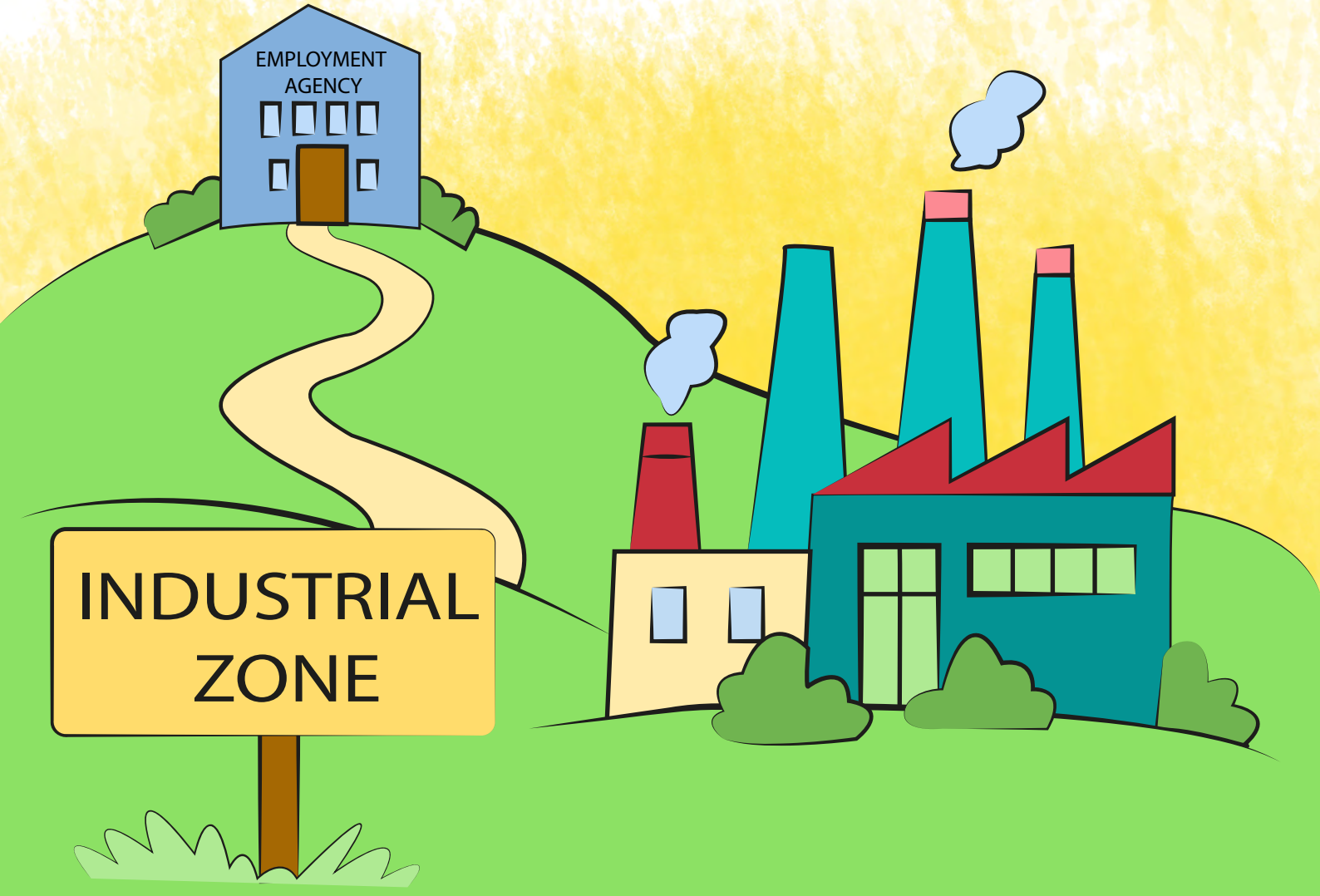
1 Employers and the PES: a relationship to be strengthened



International standards framework

The challenges of successful intermediation

Labour market realities

PES: an image requiring a new lease of life

Why should the Public Employment Service (PES) support employers? This is indeed an interesting question. Why should a public service support private employers, and do it for free? The answer lies in the primary mission of the PES: intermediation. Public employment agencies, at both national and local level, must make it easier for jobseekers to find work. This implies a professional, regular and effective relationship with these two audiences. But while jobseekers have no trouble accessing public employment agencies, employers do. The observation is the same in almost all countries (albeit with varying degrees of intensity): too few employers entrust their job vacancies to the PES. But how can intermediation be achieved without a job offer? It is therefore essential for the PES to strengthen their relations with employers.

▶ International standards framework

On the subject of PES, Convention No. 88 (1) of the International Labour Organisation (ILO) is the reference text. Adopted in 1948 and ratified by 92 countries, it sets out very clearly the tasks and activities of the PES.

The latter "shall ... **ensure**, in co-operation where necessary with other public and private bodies concerned, **the best possible organisation of the employment market ... for the achievement and maintenance of full employment ..."**

"The employment service shall consist of a national system of employment offices under the direction of a national authority; to this end, **it shall assist workers to find suitable employment and assist employers to find suitable workers,** it shall:

- Register applicants for employment, take note of their occupational qualifications, experience and desires, (...) and assist them where appropriate to obtain vocational guidance or vocational training or retraining,
- **Obtain from employers precise information on vacancies (...) and the requirements to be met by the workers whom they are seeking,**
- Refer to available employment applicants with suitable skills and physical capacity, "

Article 10 further states: "The employment service and other public authorities where appropriate shall, in co-operation with employers' and workers' organisations and other interested bodies, take all possible measures to **encourage full use of employment service facilities by employers and workers on a voluntary basis.** "

Each country that has ratified an ILO convention must bring its legislation and national organisation into line, and then report to the ILO at regular intervals on its implementation.

Less well known is ILO Recommendation No. 83 (2), also adopted in 1948, which sets out, among other things, a number of important points on "The orientation of workers towards available employment: The employment service should:

- not, in referring workers to employment, itself discriminate against applicants on grounds of race, colour, sex or belief."
- In directing workers to jobs, refrain from itself applying discriminatory measures to job applicants based on considerations of race, colour, sex or creed.

Although these two texts date back more than three-quarters of a century, their principles remain relevant and topical.

The challenges of successful intermediation

Apart from the importance for a country of complying with an international convention that it has chosen to ratify, the benefits of an intense and effective relationship between the PES and the business world are major. It is clear that successful intermediation is positive for all relevant parties:

- For jobseekers who are no longer unemployed in this way;
- For employers integrating the skills of a new employee to help their business run more smoothly;
- For the country's economy, which benefits from smoother business operations and lower unemployment.
- For the government, which has everything to gain from a flourishing economy and a calm social climate.

In addition, when intermediation is facilitated by the PES, it also takes into account the professional integration of the most vulnerable groups. Unlike private employment agencies, whose primary objective is financial profitability, the PES, as a public service, must contribute to restoring equity in the labour market. It must give priority to helping those who need it most, to promote their profiles and skills, and to identify recruitment opportunities. These may include people with little autonomy in their job search, young people with no professional experience, people with disabilities, or people who may be discriminated against in recruitment because of their gender, age, origin, sexual orientation, etc.

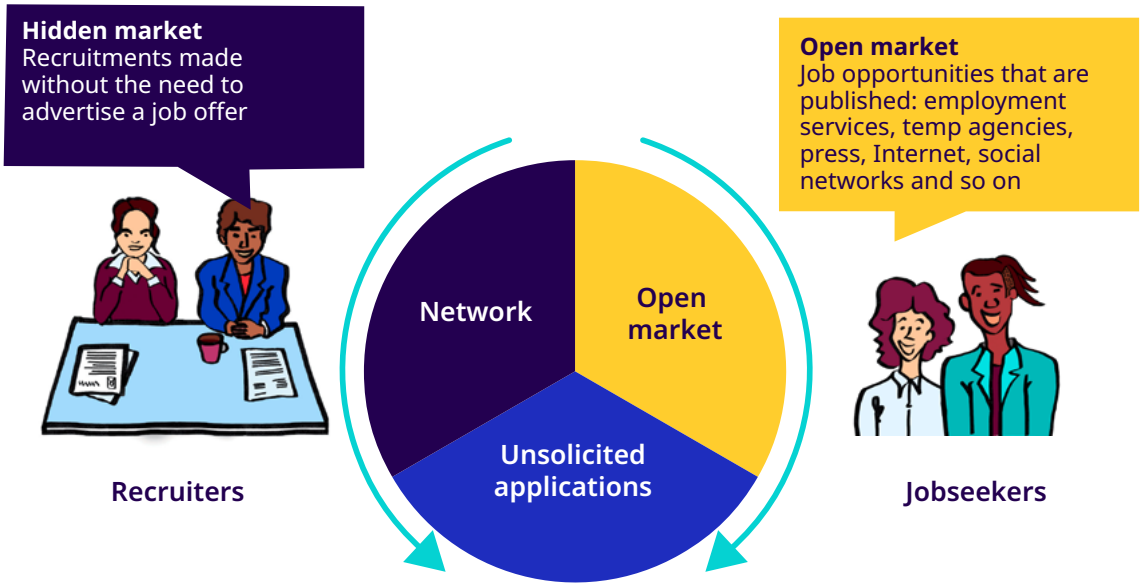
Labour market realities

To ensure that intermediation and the labour market work as smoothly as possible, the PES wants to convince employers to entrust it with their recruitment needs. However, we need to be aware that in the vast majority of situations, a private sector employer does not need to advertise a vacancy to recruit a good candidate. Why is this?

When employers in the private sector recruit, it is either to increase their workforce as a result of an economic market that is favourable to their business, or to replace an employee who is leaving. In both cases, information on this need is quickly made known within the company, and then externally. The networks of existing employees (family, friends, professional contacts) help to spread the word, generating recommendations and unsolicited applications. The employer can then make his choice and recruit the right candidate. This is the hidden market. In France, a December 2024 study published by Randstad estimates that 57% of recruitments are made without publishing a job advert. The rate is four points higher than in 2021 (3).

Even if the share of the hidden market varies greatly from one country to another, it is prevalent or very prevalent in almost all countries. "Personal contacts (informal networks) and word of mouth are the main search channels used by companies to find candidates. This is particularly true for SMEs" (4).

As a result, the so-called open market, i.e. the proportion of job opportunities that are published, often represents less than a third of a country's recruitment market. In fact, (unless there is a specific desire for transparency) it is only if they have not found a good profile via their networks and unsolicited applications that employers will decide to make their needs known by publishing a job advert on the open market.



Source: author

There are a number of options that can be combined: social networks, the company's website, the press and media, private employment agencies (including temporary work) or the Public Employment Service. It is therefore on this short competitive segment of the "open market" that the PES can exist and find its place. What is its market share (of all recruitment)? This is very difficult to calculate. Countries with a low rate of informal employment and a robust system of single declaration of recruitment can compare the number of job offers collected by the PES with the number of recruitments made each year by companies in the country. Those who reach 15% can congratulate themselves. This means that they cover a very large part of the open market. Often these rates also depend on the skill level of the vacancy. For example, data from the "European Vacancies and Recruitment Report (European Commission)" reveals a trend at EU level. For highly qualified people, the PES market share in recruitment was 7%, while the involvement for low levels of education was 11%. (5). In many cases, the market share of PESs is closer to 1 to 5%. As such, there is often considerable room for improvement.

If the PES wants to increase its market share, it is first and foremost, as we have already seen, to fully fulfil its intermediation mission by offering a large number of job offers to jobseekers registered in its files. It is also to bring greater transparency and fairness to the labour market. The most vulnerable groups often have a less extensive and less effective network to help them identify recruitment opportunities in the hidden market. If as many job vacancies as possible are advertised by the PES, this will go some way to restoring equal opportunities for the least well-informed members of the public. The PES thus becomes "the network for those who don't have one".

This guide will outline several strategies for increasing the PES's market share.

PES: an image requiring a new lease of life

Why do employers make little use of the services offered by the PES?

Through our presentation of the hidden market, we were able to explain that employers often do not need the PES to recruit. However, when they need to publish a vacancy on the open market, why are they reluctant to use the PES?

- **Lack of visibility:** Employers often don't even know that a Public Employment Service exists in their country... either because it is new, or because it is too discreet or not located throughout the country.
- **Bad reputation:** Employers may see the PES as an overly bureaucratic, cumbersome service, requiring onerous, bureaucratic procedures with no added value. Furthermore, they feel that the PES is only designed to deal with the unemployed who are alienated from the employment market, who have no qualifications, and who have a combination of obstacles preventing them from working.
- **Inadequate services:** If employers do not identify services tailored to their needs within the PES, they will have no interest in using it.
- **Lack of confidence:** The employer does not believe that the PES can provide a valid solution. In particular, many private sector employers are wary of the free services offered by the PES. For them, free equates to low quality.
- **Dissatisfaction:** Some employers who have tried out the services of the PES have come away dissatisfied. They don't want to use it again, even years later. Furthermore, they may convey a negative image to their colleagues.

All the obstacles described above help to explain why it is so difficult for a PES to convince employers to use its services. This difficulty exists all over the world, even in countries with an experienced, structured PES offering a range of services tailored to employers' needs. Creative strategies will need to be deployed over the long term to renovate the image of the PES and gradually convince a larger proportion of employers to place their trust in it.

2 Understanding employers' expectations

Diversity of private employers

Public-sector employers

Recruitment practices

Main expectations

In recent years (especially after the COVID crisis), strengthening the relationship with employers has been one of the main strategic areas of development for the PES, on all continents. Some PES even aim to position themselves as the leading "HR partner for companies", or even as the "HR department for the country". This political ambition reflects the government's desire for the PES to be sufficiently effective in its support for businesses to help reverse the trends in the labour market: youth unemployment, recruitment difficulties, low employment rates among senior citizens, etc.

▶ Diversity of private employers

To establish a strategy for strengthening relations with employers, it is essential for the PES to understand the diversity of targets and therefore of HR needs. This diversity is mainly based on size, business sector and location.

- **Size:** Between a micro-business with five employees where the boss has to do everything, a medium-sized company with 220 employees that has its own human resources department, or a large national or multinational company, the operational dynamics, the issues and the needs are obviously different. However, everyone can benefit from the services of the PES. A craftsman, for example, is an occasional recruiter and may need advice and support at every stage of the recruitment process. The SME, a regular recruiter, will want to build up a relationship of trust with a dedicated employment counsellor, to support its HR strategy throughout the year. Finally, multinationals with operations in several regions of the country may be looking for a "Key Account" (or "VIP") service that includes co-ordinated (or even centralised) management of their relations with the PES.

- **Business sector:** Fluctuations in a company's HR needs are primarily linked to its order book. This can change depending on the national or global economic climate, changes in regulations, the health of partner companies or the seasonality of the business, etc. For example, an industrial company that works as a subcontractor for a car manufacturer will see its business fluctuate according to the manufacturer's commercial success, but also according to changes in regulations, for example on internal combustion engines. A hotel business in a tourist area will be affected by the weather and the holiday calendar, but also by less usual factors such as geopolitical tensions or a pandemic. In a segmentation strategy, the sectoral approach will often be paramount.

- **Location:** The difference is mainly between companies located in highly urbanised areas and those located in rural areas. For example, a food processing plant located close to agricultural or livestock production site may find it very difficult to recruit, due to a small pool of candidates locally and/or the lack of public transport enabling its employees to get to work.

Company classification (source: ILO)

Name	Workforce
Micro-business	Less than 10 FTE
Small business	10 to 49 FTE
Medium-sized company	50 to 249 FTE
Large companies	250 FTE and more

N.B.: Micro-, small- and medium-sized enterprises are often grouped together under the term "SME".

Public-sector employers

In many countries, civil service recruitment is based on competitive examinations that guarantee equal opportunities and the selection of the best candidates (Japan: National Civil Service Entrance Examination - China: Guokao exam, with millions of candidates each year). While the competition system provides transparency with a view to merit-based selection, the process can also be lengthy and inflexible, particularly when dealing with urgent needs. Ministries often supplement their teams at national or local level by recruiting contract staff, i.e. temporary staff to strengthen the teams for a specific project or to cope with an increase in activity.

What is the relationship between the PES and public employers? The situation varies greatly from country to country. In India, for example, the PES has long served as a gateway to the civil service, enabling citizens to easily identify and apply for all public employment opportunities. On the other hand, in many countries, because of the competition procedure, public employers did not usually call on the PES to recruit on long-term contracts. In fact, they had no use for it, as they had a very large volume of applications.

It seems that the situation has changed. Becoming a "civil servant" is no longer a dream for the younger generation, particularly in public sector jobs that are in short supply: health, education and public safety. As a result, many public sector employers are now obliged to call on the PES for sourcing operations. What types of action are being taken?

- For example, the PES will be organising public safety job fairs to help the Gendarmerie, the Police and the Fire Service to recruit.
- In the run-up to competitive examinations for teacher training, the PES can also carry out dedicated initiatives to disseminate information to jobseekers with the required level of qualifications.

The PES therefore also has a role to play in supporting public employers in their HR strategy.

Recruitment practices

We have already seen that employers only decide to advertise a vacancy when they have been unable to recruit through their networks or unsolicited applications (the hidden market). They must then make their recruitment needs known, using one or more players in the open market (PES, temporary employment agencies, recruitment agencies, press and other media, social networks, internet job portals, etc.). What practices can we observe?

In competitive labour markets, employers tend to entrust the PES:

- recruitment for low-skilled jobs
- complex recruitment of technicians in sectors under pressure
- recruitment requiring financial or training assistance.

When it comes to management positions, employers tend to turn to specialist private firms.

To change practices, the PES must demonstrate its ability to act effectively on all recruitment segments. Some PES negotiate "Service Contracts" with leading companies, under which the employer promises to entrust all recruitment to the PES in exchange for a commitment to mobilise its full range of services, in a responsive manner, to meet the needs expressed (details in chapter 3).

▶ Main expectations

What are employers' expectations?

When we talk about the relationship with the PES, three main issues are regularly mentioned:

- **Ease of contact and a single point of contact:** as soon as a need arises, employers want to be able to contact their counsellor quickly (by telephone or email) and always keep the same contact person.
- **Knowledge of the company and its businesses:** employers want a relationship of trust with their counsellors and expect them to understand their business, the challenges of their professional sector, the company's businesses and their specific regulations, in order to support their projects.
- **Reactivity and efficiency:** the employer expects an immediate response to their order, relevant and useful advice on the formulation of their job offer and rapid results.

In terms of the range of services that employers expect from the PES, expectations vary according to the type of business. Here are the main ones:

1. Recruitment support

- Help in defining the profiles sought and job offers
- Simplifying and speeding up recruitment processes
- Putting you in touch with candidates who match your company's requirements. The employer usually expects the PES to pre-screen applications, in order to save time by receiving only a limited number of relevant profiles for consideration.

2. Help with Training and Skills Adaptation

- Training and skills enhancement programmes for candidates before they are hired
- Help with retraining or skills upgrading for existing employees
- Advice and support on vocational training funding schemes.

3. Advice on employment support schemes

- Information on financial assistance for recruitment (tax exemptions, subsidies, subsidised contracts)
- Advice on employment contracts tailored to employers' needs (sandwich courses, fixed-term contracts, permanent contracts, etc.)
- Legal and administrative support on employment law and regulatory obligations. However, PES counsellors are not legal experts and cannot take the place of the labour inspectorate).

4. Digital Services

- Efficient and intuitive digital platforms for posting vacancies and searching for candidates
- Direct and continuous access to a database of qualified candidates

5. Human Resources (HR) Management Support

- HR diagnostics for VSEs with no in-house HR department
- Help in anticipating recruitment and talent management needs
- Advice on integrating new employees

6. Developing Local Partnerships

- Networking with other companies, training organisations and local institutions
- Creation of targeted job dating and recruitment events
- Assistance with issues specific to certain sectors under pressure

The PES are therefore expected to be strategic partners, able to offer solutions tailored to the specific needs of companies, while reducing administrative obstacles and facilitating the recruitment and integration of talent.

3 PES services for employers

- Support for recruitment
- Use of digital solutions
- Tailor-made support
- Governmental aid for recruitment

If the PES wants to convince employers to place their trust in it, it needs to define, build and implement a solid service offering that meets their expectations. In recent years, this range of services has been expanded.

▶ Support for recruitment

Although the relationship between the employer and the PES may cover other subjects (see the following sections), recruitment is clearly the primary reason for meeting with the PES. The counsellor must consider the full importance of this project. In micro-, small- or medium-sized businesses, the decision to recruit is not a trivial one. This project represents the future of the company. Before making a decision, the company director must have weighed up what is at stake. It must ensure that it has the financial capacity to take on a new employee and assess the positive impact of this recruitment on increasing its production capacity, and therefore its sales. For micro-businesses, bringing on board a new employee can also have a major impact on internal organisation and human relations.

Onboarding the employer: Counsellors need to be aware of this situation when employers come to them with their recruitment plans. It will ensure that it fully assumes its advisory role. The employment counsellor must do more than simply take an order. They must:

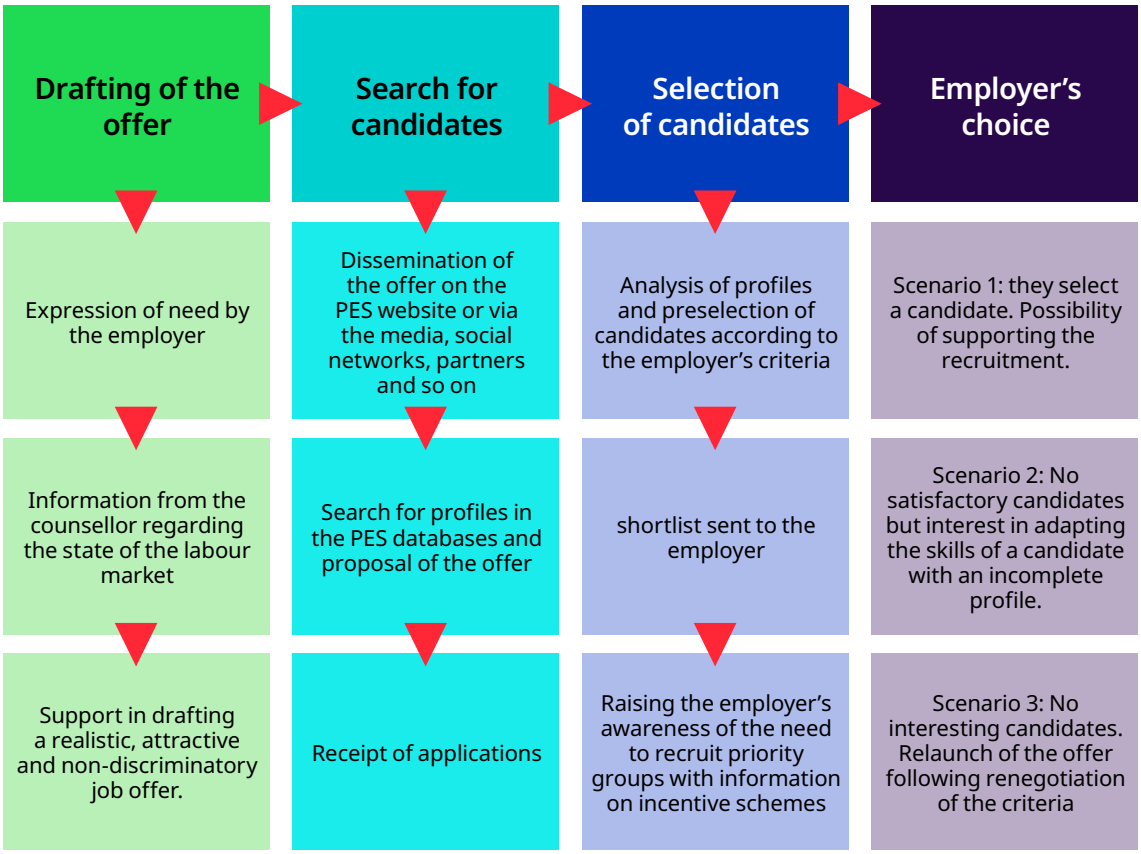
- Listen to the employer's plans,
- Ask questions to analyse the actual needs, then reformulate the to make sure the situation is fully understood,
- Inform the employer about the state of the job market in his sector and the job in question: supply/demand ratio, warning about foreseeable difficulties in finding candidates with the required profile, salaries and working conditions offered by competitors, etc
- Help the employer draw up a clear, precise, realistic and attractive job offer that complies with the rules on non-discrimination.

▶ Fight against discrimination in hiring:

When it comes to recruitment, the only elements that need to be taken into consideration when selecting candidates are their knowledge and skills, both technical and behavioural.

There is no justification for discriminatory selection based on gender, age, disability, origin, beliefs, etc. The employment counsellor is responsible for ensuring compliance with the law in this area. The advisor must educate the employer. By agreeing to record and circulate a job offer containing discriminatory criteria, he would be complicit in an unlawful action by the employer.

Process of handling a job offer



Search for candidates: As soon as the job advertisement has been drafted, the search for candidates begins. As shown in the diagram, the PES relies on two main sources:

- Firstly, the database of jobseekers registered with the PES. The counsellor will identify profiles that match the employer's expectations. He will contact them to tell them about the vacancy, assess their interest in the position and encourage them to apply.
- Secondly, the job vacancy shall be advertised via various channels, in order to publicise the employer's requirements and generate additional applications. For dissemination, the PES generally rely on their website and wall or digital displays in employment agencies. More and more PES are also advertising job vacancies on social networks, in the more traditional media (press, radio, television) and through a network of close partners. The variety and effectiveness of the ways in which job vacancies are advertised is a strong argument for employers to entrust their recruitment to the PES. This enables them to communicate their needs more effectively. Wide distribution also generates a greater variety of applications.

Selection of candidates: The method of contacting the employer is negotiated when the job offer is drawn up. For urgent or mass recruitment (seasonal agricultural workers, for example), the employer will choose to publish the vacancy by name and receive applications directly.

In other cases, the vast majority of employers request and appreciate pre-screening of applications by the PES. This prevents them from being swamped by a mass of sometimes inappropriate CVs. The counsellor will receive and acknowledge all applications. The candidate is then shortlisted on the basis of criteria agreed

with the employer, and a "short list" is sent to the employer, the size of which has been agreed in advance (on average, 3 to 5 profiles for a vacancy). At this stage, the counsellor can also inform the employer about the eligibility of certain candidates for recruitment assistance schemes (see the chapter on Active Labour Market Policies). In so doing, he plays his part in encouraging the recruitment of priority groups.

Employer's choice: At the end of the selection process, it is up to the employer to make the recruitment decision. The counsellor only provides support and information to the recruiter.

- ***Assumption 1:*** the employer identifies a good candidate among the people he has met and decides to recruit him. In this case, the counsellor may be able to support the recruitment process by offering advice on how to integrate the candidate successfully into the company, or by setting up a recruitment support scheme, if both the applicant and the employer are eligible.
- ***Assumption 2:*** the employer identifies a profile among the candidates that interests him, but the person does not have all the skills expected. In this case, some PES may offer to organise and finance a short training course aimed at adapting the candidate's profile prior to recruitment.
- ***Assumption 3:*** The employer is not satisfied with the candidates proposed. The search must then continue to generate new applications. At this stage, it is advisable to discuss the job offer criteria again with the employer. If the first distribution was not satisfactory, it is probably best to re-draft the offer to take into account the realities of the labour market. Either lower the level of requirements for the profile sought, or make the offer more attractive in terms of salary or working conditions.

▶ Five tips for recruiters:

1. **A clear, precise, detailed and attractive job advert.** With an unclear job advert, you run the risk of generating a large number of unsuitable applications and wasting time.
2. **A job offer that is realistic in terms of the market.** There's no need to pile up a list of required knowledge, skills and experience, or you'll run the risk of not finding anyone. Indicate the essential elements, the rest will be a plus.
3. **Always post a remuneration package that is appropriate for the position.** Nobody works for free. To attract the right candidates, it's important to be transparent about the level of salary on offer. This does not preclude negotiation and adjustments based on the profile during the final stages of recruitment.
4. **Respond to every application.** Out of respect for the candidates who have expressed an interest in working with you and for the good image of the company (employer brand), it is important to respond to everyone. Either a negative response, with explanations if possible, or a wait-and-see response between each phase of the recruitment process, so as not to leave the candidate with no feedback.
5. **Ensuring a high-quality welcome and integration.** There's no point in recruiting a good candidate if you fail to integrate them and they leave the company during their trial period. The first few days are crucial. New employees must be given the information and conditions they need to understand the company, their job and perform their tasks effectively. Integration into the team is essential.

PES toolbox: During the recruitment support process, some PES deploy specific measures:

- ***Job analysis:*** when recruitment is going to be complex, for specialised or unusual jobs, it's a good idea to suggest that the employer carry out a job analysis. Carried out in the company by the PES counsellor, this involves an external view of a workstation for a few hours, using a study grid. Through visual observations and discussions with the people carrying out the activity and the supervisors, the counsellor will be able to identify the knowledge, skills and working conditions that characterise the position, so that this information can be used in the recruitment phase.

- ***Immersion in a company:*** this tool is of interest to both job seekers and employers. This involves scheduling a period of discovery in a company (2 to 5 days) during which a jobseeker can discover a branch of activity and a trade, and test himself, without actually being in a production situation. For jobseekers, it's an opportunity to refine their thinking about their career plans. For employers, it's an opportunity to raise awareness of their business and their professions, to encourage people to apply, and even to identify and test people they could recruit in the future.

In Algeria, the "Immersion Découverte en Entreprise" scheme has been deployed since 2024 by ANEM in the agri-food sector. It is free for both employers and jobseekers. It provides for the creation of a pool of candidates interested in the sector, so that we can offer them appropriate training before recruitment.

- ***Single-company job dating:*** Some employers do not have the capacity to organise recruitment interviews on their premises. The PES then offers to organise the recruitment sessions directly at the local employment agency. A dedicated counsellor will organise the meetings and logistics, and provide the employer with a dedicated space. This makes it possible to identify the employment agency as a place of recruitment, and not just a place dedicated to unemployment.
- ***Recruitment forum:*** Throughout the world, the PES regularly organises recruitment forums. This is the most effective and visible way of bringing together employers in a geographical area and job seekers.

These forums can be general or themed, linked for example to seasonal activities (hotels and catering), or to national events: Industry Week, Green Jobs Week. Finally, online recruitment forums have developed strongly in the wake of the COVID 19 pandemic.

In Egypt, the Youth Centre and the Luxor employment office jointly organise a one-day recruitment forum every month on their premises, bringing together the main companies in the sector with expressed needs and motivated jobseekers. Individual interviews take place throughout the day.

▶ Use of digital solutions

As in any service company, digital tools are used extensively by PES, both to improve the efficiency of their internal operations and to enhance customer relations. As an ILO study reveals in 2021, the majority of countries want to develop their digital services, while maintaining a customer service and face-to-face relationship, particularly for less autonomous customers. This is the complementary "phygital" approach, which combines physical and digital delivery.

PES website: The website is the central pillar of the PES digital service offering. Initially, the aim was to advertise job vacancies widely in order to generate applications. The Internet offered a wide range of job opportunities, breaking down geographical barriers. Today, the strategy is more ambitious. The aim is to give the most independent employers access to PES services, 24/7, to manage their recruitment and other procedures. As with other service companies, employers will be able to create their own dedicated space, where they can enter their job offers directly and manage them until they are closed. Employers are particularly interested in the possibility of direct access to banks of profiles. It can sort and consult CVs from jobseekers, then contact some of them to offer its services. Technological advances have made it possible to select profiles very effectively, offering employers a reduced list of candidates. Some sites will also offer employers the option of managing other procedures online, such as putting together aid applications or applying for work permits.

Other digital vectors of the PES: Mobile applications are highly complementary tools to the website, as mobile phones are now the primary means of accessing digital content. In several countries, for example, the PES offer dedicated applications for accessing job vacancies. The use of social networks is also growing. PESs are adapting to new uses by taking advantage of the responsiveness and algorithms of these systems, to promote their visibility. Finally, artificial intelligence (AI) is also making inroads into the PES, particularly in terms of internal operations. For example, AI can be beneficial in replacing "humans" to check that large numbers of applications meet the profile criteria set out in a job advertisement. This saves advisers a great deal of time, freeing them up to focus on recruitment support activities that require greater expertise.

The first reason why PES use digital technology is to entrust low-tech, easily automated activities to the machine, freeing up operational time so that advisers can devote themselves to more expert activities, for more complex cases or less autonomous customers.

Against this backdrop, the challenge of IT security is one that PESs must address. The more it uses digital technology, the more vigilant it needs to be to anticipate and counter attempts at fraud and piracy by criminal organisations seeking to seize sensitive data held by the PES on companies and jobseekers, in order to resell it.

Tailor-made support

As we explained earlier, recruitment is the primary reason for contact with the PES. However, the employer may have other interests in the relationship with the PES.

Support for long-term projects: Building up a relationship of trust with your employment counsellor over the years means you can be more effective every time you recruit. The counsellor has a thorough understanding of the company, its businesses, its expectations and its constraints, and can therefore identify the most suitable candidates for each vacancy. The counsellor can also be proactive. For example, if they interview a jobseeker whose profile matches the company's recurring needs, they can "push" the CV towards the company, even if no vacancy is currently being advertised.

Confidence is the key to anticipation. Imagine an SME planning to open a new production site in two years' time. By involving the PES counsellor in the preparation of the project, it will be possible to identify the job profiles, pinpoint any tensions in these professions, identify and motivate jobseekers willing to change direction, build up a pool and train them in advance, so that all the jobs can be filled when the new site opens.

Service contract: For major employers at national level (Key Accounts) or for major companies at local level, the PES can propose a bilateral commitment through a "Service Contract". This approach aims to foster a relationship of trust and proximity between the PES and the company, with a view to improving efficiency and service quality. These contracts may include the following commitments:

- For the PES: designate a single point of contact, who can be contacted quickly (direct telephone number + email address), commit to response times and to taking requests into account, make immersion or training schemes easy to use, tailor-made services, etc.
- For the employer: commitment to entrust all recruitment to the PES, appointment of a single contact person within the Human Resources department, ease of contact, reporting on each candidate proposed by the PES, facilitating work placements, particularly for people in vulnerable situations, etc.

Information on the labour market: The PES is an expert in the labour market and recruitment. Confronted on a daily basis with the expectations of employers and the profiles of jobseekers, the PES is able to analyse trends, tensions and changes in practices on an ongoing basis. It is therefore a valuable source of information for the employer. For example, in the context of climate change, which is having a major impact on the development of professions, the PES can advise companies on their Strategic Workforce Planning (SWP), in particular to prepare for the green transition.

▶"Learn to recruit" workshops

In Mexico, the Servicio Nacional de Empleo (SNE) has set up workshops for employers, particularly SMEs, to help them understand the labour market, teach them how to write an effective and realistic job advertisement, raise awareness of discriminatory criteria and teach them how to conduct a recruitment interview using role-playing. Each workshop lasts two hours, in three modules. They are scheduled throughout the country. 4,000 companies benefit every year. The workshop evaluation barometer shows satisfaction and effectiveness.

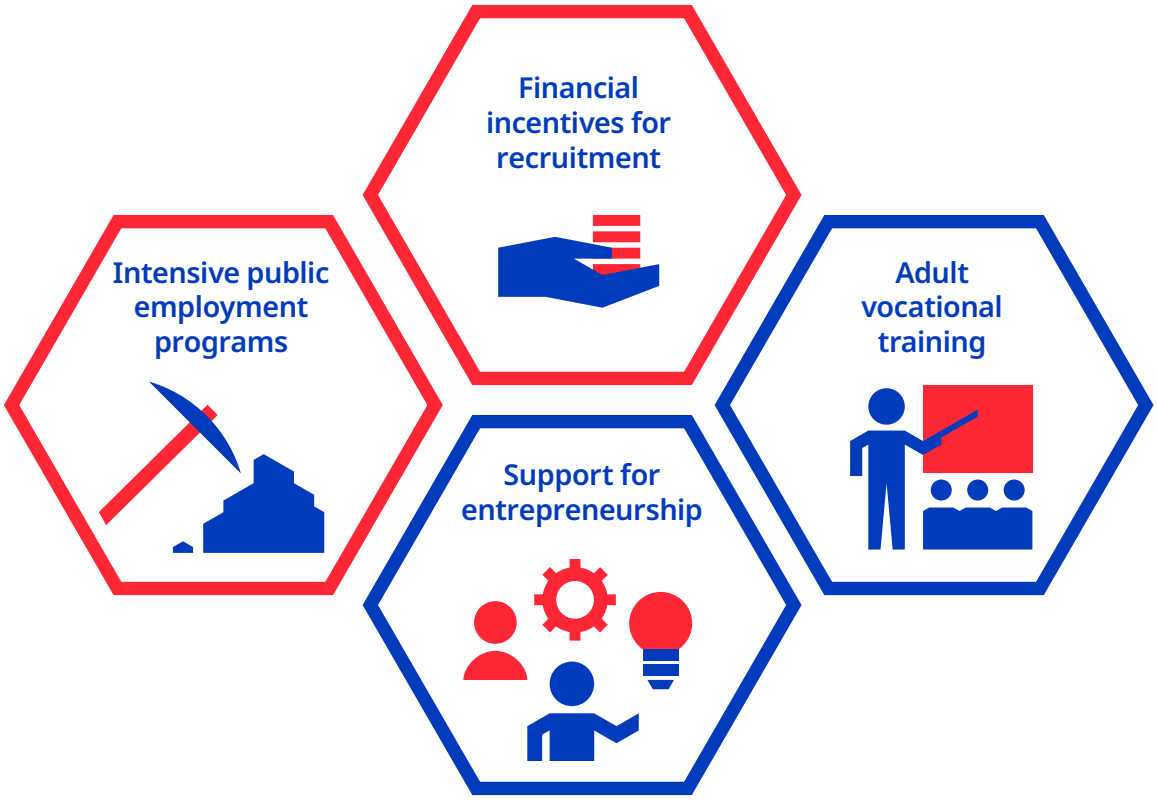
▶ Governmental aid for recruitment

In some countries, governments have chosen to intervene in the labour market in an attempt to regulate it, establish greater social justice and equity and encourage job creation. These interventions take two main forms. On the one hand, the preparation and voting of legislative and regulatory texts aimed at strengthening the country's social legislation, and on the other, Labour Market Policies. The Public Employment Service very often becomes the government's operational arm for promoting and implementing these schemes.

Labour Market Policies aim to offer income support and/or professional integration measures to jobseekers, the underemployed, employees looking for a better job or young people in transition between school and work. They fall into two categories:

- **Passive labour market policies:** aim to replace income during periods of unemployment or job search and include measures such as:
  - Unemployment insurance benefits, for those who have paid sufficient contributions, calculated in proportion to previous salaries.
  - Flat-rate integration allowances paid by the State.
- **Active labour market policies:** aim to reduce unemployment and keep people linked to the labour market.
  - Supporting and promoting entrepreneurship and self-employment
  - Intensive public employment programmes
  - Training programmes in line with labour market needs
  - Subsidies and recruitment aid

Active Labour Market Policies



Let's take a look at recruitment grants and subsidies. The government is pursuing two main objectives with these measures:

- Firstly, to support job creation, particularly in micro and small businesses, by strengthening their capacity to recruit. Example: support for hiring the first employee for sole traders.
- Secondly, to promote access to employment for the most disadvantaged people, who are then identified as "priority groups" for government policies. The following categories are most often mentioned: young people looking for their first work experience, disabled people, older workers, long-term jobseekers.

What type of recruitment aid is available? These measures are designed to provide an incentive, and most often result in a financial advantage for the recruiter:

- Either by paying a bonus for the recruitment of targeted people
- Either by the State paying part of the salary
- Or by partial or total exemption from social security contributions payable by the company for the recruitment of the new employee.

The deployment of these schemes is often entrusted to the PES as the operational structure in contact with jobseekers and businesses. For the PES, this can be a very useful lever for encouraging certain employers who are reluctant to hand over their job vacancies. They see a significant financial interest in it. The PES can then attract the employer by implementing the financial measure, and then continue to work with the company on its other needs, outside the aid schemes.

In Tunisia, the National Agency for Employment and Self-Employment (ANETI) is tasked by the State with implementing a number of measures to encourage employment and/or facilitate recruitment:

- Professional Life Initiation Contract (CIVP)
- Civil Service Contract (CSC)
- The Support Programme for the Recruitment of Higher Education Graduates (PARDES)
- The Adaptation Action Programme to improve employability

With different objectives, these different programmes can combine the payment of grants, exemption from social security charges, funding for training, recruitment bonuses, etc

www.emploi.net.tn/ Employment incentive programmes

Beware of the windfall effect. The aim of recruitment aid is to trigger a positive decision by a company that has been reluctant to recruit, often for financial reasons. This helps to create jobs, particularly for people in vulnerable situations.

What we call the "windfall effect" refers to a company that had already planned to recruit, outside the aid scheme, but which is finally going to take advantage of the scheme, by meeting the criteria laid down.

What's more problematic is the case of certain companies that provide one recruitment subsidy after another, without ensuring that the employees remain with the company over the long term. Example: recruitment of a young person whose salary will be subsidised for one year. The contract ends after 12 months and is replaced by a new young person who is entitled to the same support. Aware of these situations of abuse, governments are trying to put in place procedures to safeguard against them. The aim is to ensure that the new employee remains with the company over the long term. This means that the company can gradually get used to paying the full salary as the new employee's skills and productivity increase.

4 Different strategic and organisational approaches

Team specialisation

Segmentation and marketing approach

Partnership approach

We have already stressed how important it is for a PES to be in professional contact with as many employers as possible. This is essential to promote transparency in the labour market and to ensure the success of the intermediation mission. To strengthen their position with employers, different PES strategies can be observed around the world. Some countries have opted for constraint. The aim is to impose a legal obligation on employers to use the services of the PES when recruiting. The PES then has a monopoly on recruitment. This approach, which was widely used at the end of the twentieth century, gives the PES the image of a bureaucratic and restrictive organisation. In addition, the monopoly given to the PES often proves difficult to enforce, due to a lack of the necessary means of control and sanctions. In the competitive context of private services and digital tools, rather than imposing constraints, it is now more appropriate for the PES to seek to convince employers by offering quality organisation and services tailored to their expectations.

▶ Team specialisation

Specialisation is a strong trend in the PES, which is investing in strengthening its relationship with employers. This choice can be made in three ways, which can be combined:

- Agencies dedicated to employers
- Sector specialisation
- Advisers dedicated to employers

Agencies dedicated to employers:

The usual PES organisational model is based on a national network of employment agencies covering the entire country to provide local services to both job seekers and employers. Some countries have chosen to complement this organisation by setting up a national agency dedicated to employers. In general, this involves dedicating a team to so-called key accounts. These are national or international companies with a number of sites in different parts of the country, looking for a single, centralised point of contact capable of managing all the company's HR projects. These dedicated agencies work in coordination with the country's regional or local agencies, particularly when it comes to sourcing.

Sector specialisation:

The usual organisational model in the PES is that of multi-skilling. This modality is based on the idea that the employment counsellor, in order to achieve quality intermediation, must be as familiar with jobseekers' profiles as with companies' needs. Therefore, employment advisers divide their time between monitoring a portfolio of jobseekers and supporting a portfolio of employers. But the world of employment is vast and complex. It's impossible to know every professional sector, its trades, its regulations and its challenges. Some PES have therefore opted for sector specialisation, focusing on the key economic sectors in the employment area. For example, the counsellor will focus specifically on the construction sector. They will be required to develop their expertise in this sector: knowledge of the professions, recruitment seasonality, expected skills, professional regulations, training, etc. They will only deal with jobseekers and employers in this sector.

Sectoral specialisation can also be applied to the organisation of the PES employment agency network. In large towns with several employment agencies, the customer base can be divided either geographically or by sector of activity. Agencies will then be tasked with deploying their services in three or four key economic sectors. For example: hotels, industry, transport, retail.

Dedicated advisers for employers:

Instead of relying on multi-skilled advisers, more and more SPEs are choosing to have specialised advisers. They feel that the business is too vast for their agents to master all its facets. Some counsellors are therefore dedicated to supporting jobseekers, others to serving employers and companies.

Roles, positioning and skills of the dedicated employer counsellor

An expert in their field, they greet their client, listen to their expressed expectations and ask questions to identify and define their real need, before recommending a service or product suited to the employer's needs. They provide the client with useful information and can, if necessary, refer them to other more relevant contact persons. They are guided in their actions by concern for client satisfaction."

In addition to the core professional skills of the counsellor, the employer counsellor will need to acquire specific skills:

- **Knowledge of the business world**: the counsellor must learn and understand the economic and social operation of a private company. If they have not already worked in the private sector, it is advisable to allow them to complete one or more immersion and discovery placements in a company.
- **Commercial approach:** In order to speak a common language with the employer and to know how to present arguments concerning their service offer while prospecting, it is useful for the counsellor to be trained in the commercial approach. This implies negotiation skills.
- **Information and economic monitoring:** In order to develop and maintain their thematic and/or sectoral expertise, counsellors must continuously monitor current events in their employment area, the life of companies, the evolution of professions and products and the like. They must be curious about economic and social current affairs, consult statistics on the labour market, read the local, regional, national and specialised press and so on.

Employment counsellors are often apprehensive about their relationship with the employer. They often feel an inferiority complex towards the manager. A solid training programme and development of their expertise will enable them to approach the employer relationship with more confidence.

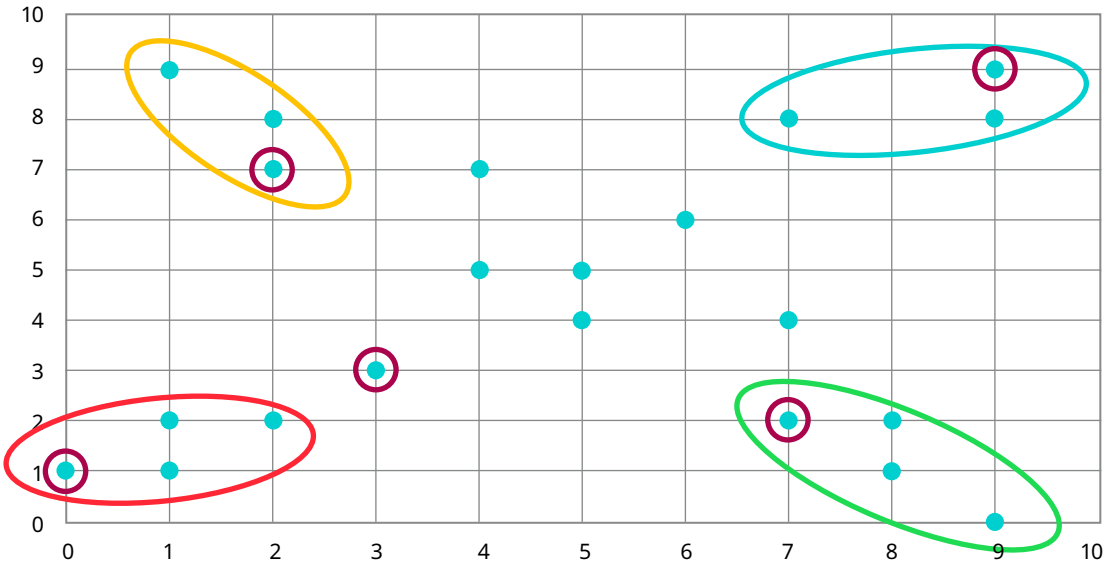
Segmentation and marketing approach

The PES does not have unlimited human resources, so he must aim for efficiency. To win new employer customers, the PES must therefore identify the most profitable targets. This involves a segmentation approach. In general, the priority is to identify employers with high recruitment potential who do not yet use the services of the PES, or who do so infrequently. Other categories may also be of interest. In the example shown in the diagram below, five types of employer have been identified:

- **In green are the hidden treasures:** major recruiters who are not, or only to a limited extent, customers of the PES
- **In blue, the golden customers:** major and loyal recruiters for the PES
- **In orange, loyal customers:** contribute little because they are weak recruiters
- **In red, targets of no interest:** non-customers with little recruitment potential

- **In purple, opinion leaders:** may be present in each category and it is important to take care of them, whatever their hiring potential, because they help to convey the image of the PES. In this category we find, for example, company directors who hold an important position within the chamber of commerce or an employers' association, or who are elected at local, regional or national level.

Recruitment potential // Clients



Horizontally, the company's recruitment potential and vertically, the frequency of customer contact with the PES

The segmentation approach will serve as a basis for the PES to establish its commercial strategy for canvassing employers. Prospecting is an important function of the counsellor. The aim is to meet new employers in order to convince them to become a customer of the PES by entrusting their recruitment to us. Several strategic choices have been made:

- Some PES focus on collecting job offers that match the profiles of jobseekers in their databases (for example, low-skilled profiles). They are looking for maximum efficiency.
- Other PES aim to collect as many job offers as possible, with a view to bringing greater transparency to the labour market, even if they do not necessarily have any corresponding profiles to offer in their database. This helps raise awareness of sectors and occupations in short supply (e.g. medical professions), to give visibility to people seeking career guidance.

Partnership approach

Employer canvassing is essential to growing the customer base. The PES must be aware that this is a long-term project (several years) if the PES is to significantly increase its market share. In addition to canvassing companies on an individual basis, a number of complementary approaches are needed:

Partnership with professional associations:

Whatever the country, the business world is generally well structured. There are several types of organisations that bring employers together, enabling them to represent their interests:

- Consular chambers: Chamber of Commerce and Industry, Chamber of Trades (for craft trades), Chamber of Agriculture
- Employers' unions and federations
- Sectoral or geographical trade associations
- Association of HR Directors (Human Resources Directors), etc.

For the PES, it is very useful to establish and maintain close links with the representatives of these employers' organisations. They are the right people to talk to, open to sharing information about what's going on in the business world, their concerns, their projects and their expectations. For example, they can contribute to the work that the PES will be carrying out to improve its service offering. These professional organisations keep their members regularly informed via newsletters, internal journals, social networks or face-to-face meetings. As part of a high-quality partnership relationship, the PES may request the use of these types of information media to publicise its services.

The HRD association is mainly made up of large and medium-sized companies in the sector. It is a key partner in the PES strategy. The PES speaks the same language as the HRDs, and thematic discussions can be held. Some PES have set up an "HR club", taking the initiative to bring together and lead HR managers at regional or local level.

Partnerships with leading companies: a strategy of influence

As part of its drive to win new customers, the PES needs to develop its image in the business world. One of the most effective ways of doing this is to get the message across to large companies that are familiar with and satisfied with the services provided by the PES.

To successfully implement this influence strategy, the PES needs to identify key accounts that are well known and have a positive image at national or regional level. Certain identified companies committed to professional and social integration (socially responsible companies) could be prime targets. The aim is to convince them to entrust their job vacancies to the PES, to carry out their recruitment successfully, and then to convince them to talk to their peers. A flagship company that shows its satisfaction will always have more impact than direct communication from the PES. The company becomes an ambassador for the PES, a trusted partner with whom the relationship should be nurtured over the long term.

5 Dealing with recruitment difficulties

Anticipating labour needs

Enhancing the employability of jobseekers

Innovative solutions to encourage intermediation

Recruitment difficulties are a problem that affects many economic sectors and countries. In Europe, more than half of employers say they are finding it difficult to hire; this figure has risen in recent years.

▶ Europe's main sectors with significant labour shortages (Eurostat)

- Technical and industrial professions
- Health and personal assistance
- Transport and logistics
- Digital and technologies
- Hotels, restaurants and tourism
- Building and civil engineering
- Education
- Agriculture and agri-food

Why are companies struggling to recruit? The causes vary from region to region and sector to sector, but a number of common trends emerge:

- **Skills shortage**
  - Technological, climatic and demographic changes are transforming our professions, some of which are disappearing while ne w ones are emerging. These new jobs require specific skills that candidates do not yet possess.
  - For example, digitisation and automation are creating an increased demand for technological profiles. The ageing of the population in some countries is creating a major need for jobs in care and personal services.
- **Lack of attractiveness of certain professions**
  - In the construction, hotel and catering or health sectors, difficult working conditions (long hours, physical workload, stress) discourage applicants.
  - Remuneration deemed insufficient for the requirements of the job.
- **Geographical mismatch**
  - Jobs are not always located where the workers are situated.
  - One difficulty is the lack of mobility of potential candidates to regions where jobs are available. This is sometimes due to the fact that the cost of living is too high in certain regions, preventing low-income earners from finding accommodation.
- **Changing employee expectations**
  - Teleworking is on the rise: some applicants are turning down jobs that do not allow them to telework.
  - Search for meaning and balance: more and more workers want jobs that are aligned with their values and a better work-life balance.
- **Immigration and visa issues**
  - In many countries, restrictive policies prevent vacancies from being filled with talent from abroad.
  - Conversely, the migration of skilled workers to countries offering better wages or living conditions creates shortages in the countries of origin.

The Public Employment Services have a role to play, in partnership with the other players in the labour market, in identifying and activating solutions to facilitate a better match between job supply and demand.

Anticipating labour needs

The PES is a forward-looking stakeholder. One of its missions is to produce and disseminate new information on labour market trends (recruitment tensions, changes in professions and skills, changes in recruitment practices, etc.). This information is useful for:

- Jobseekers and young schoolchildren considering their career direction
- Companies that need to deepen their understanding of the realities of their business sector
- Education and training structures, to adapt their programmes to changes in the professions
- Policy-makers to plan active labour market policies.

To this end, in many countries (e.g. ANAPEC in Morocco), the PES organises and implements surveys (often on an annual basis) on changes in companies' recruitment practices and workforce requirements. The aim is to interview as many employers as possible, in order to identify changes in trends from one year to the next. The results of these surveys are invaluable. For example, it can be used to identify the positions in which companies are planning to recruit heavily, region by region, and to make a comparison with the pool of potential candidates registered in the PES files.

The labour market **supply/demand** ratio is a key indicator that measures the balance between the number of job vacancies available (or recruitment forecasts) and the number of applicants seeking a position in a given sector.

- If the ratio is low (less than 1) → There are more applicants than positions available, leading to increased competition between applicants for jobs.
- If the ratio is high (greater than 1) → There are more job offers than available candidates. The sector is experiencing a labour shortage. This is the case for short-staffed occupations, where employers are struggling to recruit.

Example: companies in one town have announced that they will be recruiting a large number of bus drivers for school transport from September onwards. The PES notes that the supply/demand ratio is high (lack of potential candidates). The PES must therefore develop a strategy to anticipate the need expressed. What actions should be taken?

- Meet with the relevant employers to refine the requirements: job profile, skills, working conditions and offer them the opportunity to become involved in an action plan alongside the PES
- Organise "sector workshops" to present the bus driver positions to jobseekers from other professional sectors, in order to arouse their interest in retraining. These "sector workshops" involve the presence of employers to present the profession and their companies and encourage interest. The aim is to improve the image of the profession.
- Offer "work experience placements" to interested parties. The aim is to give them the opportunity to find out about the profession and observe working conditions for a few days in a company, to see if the job is right for them.
- Build up a pool of validated profiles for a career change to bus driver.
- Organise, plan and finance the training of these people, so that they are operational and ready for employment by September.

▶ Enhancing the employability of jobseekers

As part of its mission to match job supply and demand, the PES is committed to offering schemes to improve the employability of jobseekers. Employability can be hampered by a number of factors:

- Lack of technical skills or theoretical knowledge relevant to the job in question
- Interpersonal skills (people skills) out of sync with the work environment
- Social obstacles: accommodation, health, transport, etc.

Adult vocational training

The PES is not a training structure. However, it has an important role to play in adult vocational training:

- It lists (sometimes in conjunction with other partners) the vocational training on offer, by sector, by profession and by region, to make it easier for jobseekers to access this information, so that they can choose a training organisation that matches their plans.
- It provides individual advice to jobseekers to help them develop their training plans in line with their career choice.
- Mandated and financed by the government, it can decide on and plan collective or individual training initiatives in sectors and occupations in short supply, in order to adapt the skills of job seekers to labour needs. In this configuration, the PES is the ordering party. It programmes and purchases training sessions from the relevant training bodies under public procurement contracts.
- Finally, in several countries, the PES offers individual, tailor-made in-company training programmes prior to recruitment. These schemes are aimed at candidates whose profiles are close to the profile of the position to be filled, but who lack certain skills. Personalised pre-recruitment training helps to bridge the skills gap and fill the position as closely as possible to the company's needs.

Strengthening cross-disciplinary skills

- The lack of certain soft skills can also be a major barrier to access to employment. With recruitment under pressure, employers are tending to favour cross-disciplinary skills over traditional technical skills when recruiting. The ability to organise and prioritise, adaptability and autonomy make up the "top three" skills most sought after by employers.
- Jobseekers are rarely aware of this trend. They don't know how to identify their own cross-disciplinary skills, or how to promote them in their profile. The PES also has a role to play here. In Tunisia, for example, ANETI prepares young jobseekers in this area by offering them a specific support workshop.

In Rwanda, the Employment Service Centre in Kigali is working closely with the YEGO Centre (Youth Empowerment for Global Opportunity) to offer young people training to help them develop their soft skills with a view to being recruited by call centres.

Removing peripheral obstacles

- Physical barriers can hinder employability. A jobseeker who has not found a solution for looking after young children, or a means of transport to get to work, will be blocked in their access to employment, whatever the quality of their professional profile. They may need support.
- The PES is not directly responsible for social inclusion. However, as social obstacles are often a barrier, more and more PES are adopting a holistic approach. The aim is to address all the issues facing jobseekers. To achieve this, the PES works closely with social services to coordinate the support given to individuals, both in their search for employment and in resolving their social problems.
- With specific regard to geographical mobility, ILO Convention No. 88 provides that the PES must "take appropriate measures ... To facilitate geographical mobility with a view to assisting the movement of workers to areas with suitable employment opportunities". For example, some PES may offer financial assistance for geographical mobility, such as "relocation assistance".

Innovative solutions to encourage intermediation

Traditional methods of intermediation are still in the majority, but in the context of recruitment difficulties, it is necessary to innovate in order to discover and motivate talent. For the sectors affected by these difficulties (such as the hotel and catering industry in Europe), the labour market has reversed. Previously, the employer had a choice of several quality candidates and could impose its conditions. Today, in these professions, it is the candidate who has the choice between several employers and can impose his or her own expectations. Employers are forced to "seduce" the best candidates into joining their company.

Events dedicated to recruitment

Recruitment forums and job fairs go back a long way (see chapter 3), but they have only recently begun to proliferate. As mentioned above, employers need to make themselves known in order to attract the best candidates. They are in the business of seduction, trying to give the best possible image of the company through a well-decorated stand, a display of their products and demonstrations of their processes. The PES is the organiser of these events. They can be general in nature, covering a geographical area, or sector-specific (Forum des métiers de la défense, de l'industrie, du tourisme ou de la restauration). Some are even relocated to the company itself, with visits designed to give an insight into the realities of the professions and working conditions. The aim is to improve the sector's image. Finally, online trade fairs are also offered by the PES using dedicated digital platforms.

▶Breaking down barriers: the concept of reverse recruitment (France)

"An innovative format, the "Reverse Recruitment" operation was particularly popular with candidates and companies. They were invited to draw up a 'company CV' containing information about themselves and the benefits they offer. Divided into small groups with anonymous recruiters, the jobseekers were then tasked with allocating each CV to the right company. After this discovery phase, it's time to meet people: the employers reveal themselves and welcome interested candidates for one-to-one interviews."

Here's what one of the HR staff who took part in the operation had to say: "It was interesting to work on our CVs and to be able to use them for recruitment purposes. We have specified the benefits we are offering, such as sectorisation, reimbursement of mileage expenses and flexible working hours. The format helped to create a friendly, relaxed atmosphere, which builds confidence and facilitates discussions with candidates."

In other forms of reverse job dating, candidates are grouped by five or six around a table. Employers pass individually from table to table and are questioned by the candidates. Employers need to promote their company and its vacancies in order to be convincing.

Source: Le recrutement inversé : une approche innovante pour booster le secteur des services à la personne | (in French)France Travail

Solutions for identifying people skills during recruitment

The usual recruitment circuit: CV + letters + interviews, does not allow the employer to identify the behavioural qualities of the candidates they meet. We have noted that cross-disciplinary skills are now a priority for recruiters. What solution can we come up with? In France, France Travail has been experimenting for several years with recruitment methods that give both applicants and recruiters the opportunity to discover each other's behavioural qualities:

- "**Du Stade vers l'emploi" (From the stadium to employment)** is an innovative recruitment scheme run by France Travail in partnership with the French Athletics Federation. Its aim is to encourage jobseekers to enter the labour market by offering an innovative recruitment method based on behavioural skills rather than the traditional elements of a CV. The aim is to enable jobseekers and employers to meet anonymously at a stadium. Created in 2019, this sports-based scheme has been rolled out in over 200 areas (see description in the box).

- "**Employment on the menu":** In a restaurant privatised by France Travail, for three hours, without knowing who is who, employers from the catering industry and candidates from the sector work together to cook, lay the tables and serve lunch. This simulation allows employers to observe participants' interpersonal skills, team spirit and ability to collaborate, while offering candidates the opportunity to demonstrate their skills in a less stressful environment than a traditional interview.

▶"Du Stade vers l'emploi" – France Travail

1. Objectives

- Combating discrimination in recruitment by temporarily neutralising traditional selection criteria (name, age, background, qualifications, etc.).
- Promote soft skills such as team spirit, perseverance, stress management and communication.
- Create a direct, human link between recruiters and jobseekers in a different, friendlier setting than a traditional interview.

2. Organisation and proceedings

The scheme takes place over the course of a day, usually at a stadium, and is divided into two stages:

Sports morning (total anonymity)

- The participants (recruiters and candidates) take part in a sporting activity, often centred on athletics.
- There are no distinctive signs to identify the status or functions of the participants: everyone is dressed in sportswear, and CVs are not used.
- The aim is to assess attitudes and behaviour in a collective and dynamic context, without any influence from appearance or career path.

Professional afternoon (anonymity waived)

- The identities are revealed.
- Recruitment interviews are organised between the companies present and the candidates.
- These discussions are based on the observations made during the morning, supplemented by exchanges on the technical skills and career plans of the candidates.

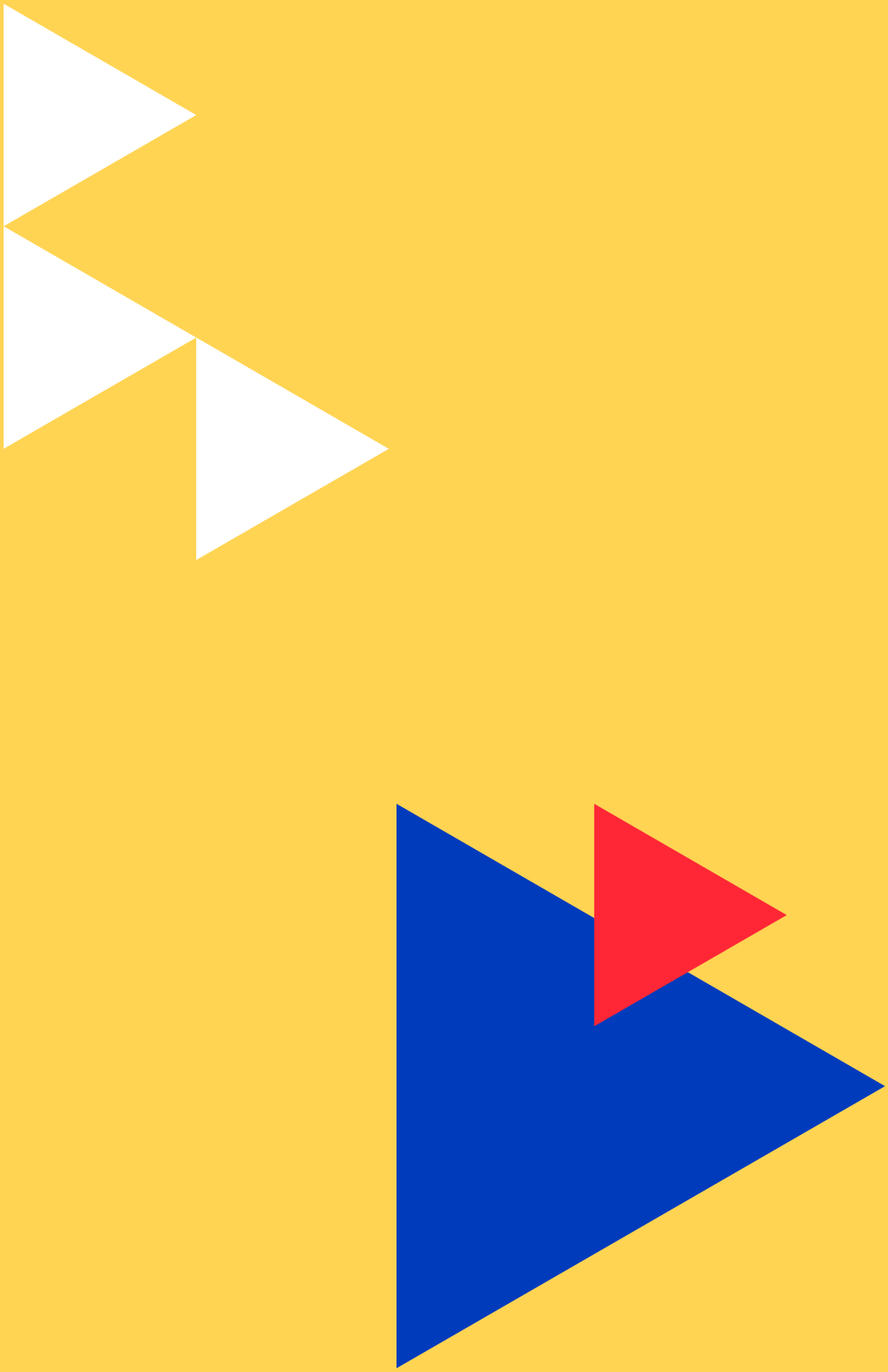
3. Benefits for participants

For jobseekers:

- Reduced stress associated with traditional interviews.
- Highlighting their soft skills.
- An opportunity to demonstrate their human qualities before analysing their career path.

For employers:

- Discovering atypical and motivated profiles.
- Recruitment based on people and personality.
- Limiting the unconscious bias associated with traditional recruitment.



6 Steering performance in employer services

Choice of production indicators

Monitoring customer satisfaction

Performance culture

As we pointed out earlier, if the PES is to win over employers, it must offer services that are tailored to their needs and effective. It must be able to demonstrate to potential customers its ability to obtain convincing results. Furthermore, in the competitive world of the labour market, the PES must be able to prove its effectiveness and be accountable to its supervisory authorities. All of this involves strengthening the organisational and managerial aspects of performance management.

▶ Choice of production indicators

For PESs that take the form of a Public Administrative Establishment, the steering indicators are generally defined in the multi-annual performance contract signed with the State. Targets or objectives are negotiated annually, in conjunction with the allocation of human and budgetary resources.

For a long time, activity with employers was measured by two indicators: the number of job offers collected and the number of placements. Today, the various practices observed enable us to identify four families of indicators:

- **Activity monitoring indicators:** number of prospecting visits to companies, number of new customers, number of job offers collected and registered, etc.
- **Performance indicators:** number of vacancies filled, number of placements, time taken to fill vacancies, market share, employer satisfaction with the services provided by the PES, etc.
- **Indicators of mobilisation of employment measures:** The aim is for the PES to report on its effectiveness in prescribing government subsidies for the recruitment of priority groups: number of subsidies prescribed, etc.
- **Quality indicators:** compliance with quality commitments, including order processing times and the number of times the telephone dedicated to employers is picked up. Quality of job offers: checking content, compliance with rules, etc.

Such a range of indicators means that the PES needs to equip itself with a computerised activity monitoring system that collects data from the internal IT system, centralises and analyses it, and produces the dashboards that are essential for management at all levels of the organisation.

▶ Vacancies / placements:

In monitoring the activity of the PES, a distinction is made between job vacancies filled and vacancies resulting in a placement, which are only a sub-part of the first indicator. Placement means that a candidate directly proposed by the PES has been selected to fill the vacancy. In other cases, the vacancy will have been filled by a candidate from a source other than the PES.

Monitoring customer satisfaction

As in other service companies, the major trend in the PES is to measure customer satisfaction: employers and jobseekers. Indeed, the general objective of a service company is to satisfy its customers. The satisfaction indicator is therefore the most closely observed barometer.

How do you measure employer satisfaction?

The most common practice is to send a satisfaction questionnaire to the employer after each recruitment operation. How should we look at it? What questions should I ask?

To make the link with the usual criticisms made by employers of the PES and their usual expectations (see chapters 1 and 2), there are several possible approaches:

- **Ease of access to services:** measure the degree of accessibility of PES services online, by telephone and in person, particularly for SMEs and new users.
- **Communication and responsiveness:** Assess the clarity, speed and reliability of communication throughout the process.
- **Skills of PES staff:** Assess the skills and capacity of staff to advise and support employers.
- **Bureaucracy and process (simplicity):** Examine employers' perception and understanding of the efficiency and user-friendliness of PES procedures, minimising delays or inefficiencies.
- **Quality and suitability of applicants:** Assess whether shortlisted candidates meet employers' expectations in terms of skills and suitability.
- **Results and impact of recruitment:** Examine whether the PES has helped to fill vacancies effectively and contributed to the success of long-term recruitment and the smooth running of the company.
- **Future intention:** Indicates whether employers are willing to use or recommend the PES again, reflecting overall satisfaction and confidence.

For the PES, which is organised to carry out these satisfaction surveys, the advantage is that the results can be monitored longitudinally, at national, regional and local level. This makes it possible to observe trends over time and analyse the reasons for changes in results, whether downwards or upwards.

In Korea, PES user satisfaction surveys are administered directly in the employment agency. As a result, the results are not always considered to be totally reliable, as employers may be reluctant to provide honest feedback, often due to their reliance on labour inspection results or government subsidies.

To remedy the limitations of these qualitative indicators, the PES has decided to supplement them with more objective measures, such as the Rate of re-use of PES services by employers.

In Spain, the SEPE (Servicio Publico de Empleo Estatal) is implementing the recommendations of the PES Network (European Network of Public Employment Services), which proposes detailed surveys based on five sub-indicators:

- **1. Quality of candidates presented:** This measures whether the candidates supplied by the public employment services meet employers' expectations and requirements in terms of skills, qualifications and suitability for the job.
- **2. Efficiency of the recruitment process:** This indicator assesses the speed and fluidity of the recruitment process, including the management of applications and communication with employers.
- **3. Support and advice for employers:** This looks at the quality of support and advice offered to employers by the public employment services, including labour market information and advice on recruitment procedures.
- **4. Overall employer satisfaction:** An overall indicator of employer satisfaction with the services received, which may include aspects such as the user-friendliness of the service, the availability of agents and the relevance of the services offered.
- **5. Impact of services on recruitment needs:** Measure of the effectiveness of public employment services in meeting employers' recruitment needs, particularly in terms of placing suitable candidates in vacant posts and reducing recruitment difficulties.

These sub-indicators are designed to provide a comprehensive and detailed view of employers' experience of public employment services, enabling these services to be continually evaluated and improved.

▶ Performance culture

A **well-designed performance management system and strategy** has many advantages for the PES:

- **Monitoring and measuring performance:** It provides performance indicators to assess whether objectives have been met, to detect deviations and monitor changes in activity, and to provide alerts, etc.
- **Reporting to the supervisory authority** on business results
- **Helping to make decisions:** By providing reliable, up-to-date data, it helps executives and managers make strategic and operational choices.
- **Involving and empowering teams:** by sharing clear objectives and assessment criteria, it encourages employee involvement and the development of a performance culture. Team members can therefore be involved in analysing the results and drawing up corrective action plans.
- **Improving efficiency and effectiveness:** It identifies the levers for optimising resources, processes and costs.

- **Promoting transparency:**
  - In-house: It makes the organisation's performance visible, improves communication with teams and aligns stakeholders around common objectives.
  - Externally, it enables communication based on objective data. By communicating on indicators and results, the PES speaks the same language as companies and improves its image with employers.

As with the rest of the business, managing the performance of the PES, in terms of service to employers, must be based on a continuous improvement approach, empowering the internal players in each territory. This involves an annual breakdown of objectives at the level of each employment area and regular performance reviews with the teams in order to analyse results and identify corrective actions to be taken. This is the famous "continuous improvement loop": Plan-Do-Check-Act, which gradually instils a performance culture.

Conclusion

In each country, in order to exist as a credible and effective entity, to play its full role in intermediation, to support a dynamic, agile and inclusive labour market, the Public Employment Service must be fully involved and present with employers. It's essential that the PES does more than just "manage unemployment".

Of course, convincing employers, deploying high-performance services, winning market share and facing up to competition from the private sector and digital technology is neither easy nor quick. The PES needs to develop a strategy for the short, medium and long term, in the knowledge that winning a legitimate place in the relationship with employers will take years of work and will constantly have to be defended. As an organisation, the PES must continually adapt to changes in its environment, to the needs and expectations of its customers and to the guidelines of its supervisory authorities. The PES must be an organisation that is both stable and solid, capable of dealing with the various crises that the country will face, but also agile and capable of innovating to meet new challenges.

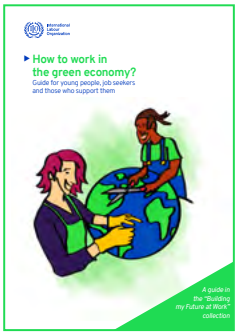
In its service to employers, the PES will be able to demonstrate the necessary agility if it cultivates its close relationships with businesses in each region, while meeting regularly with the organisations representing the economic world, consular chambers, employers' unions and federations, professional branches, etc.

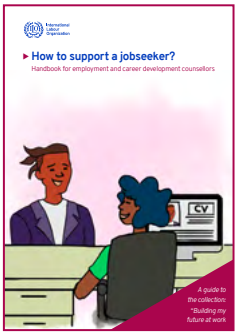
The growing number of crises in recent years fully justifies the strengthening of a public structure capable of supporting governments in the deployment of employment policies adapted to new challenges: sustainable development, demographic changes, the rise of digital technology, etc. The PES are more legitimate than ever.

▶ Useful reading

1. ILO Convention 88: Convention Co88 – Employment Service Convention, 1948 (No. 88) (ilo.org)
2. ILO Recommendation 83: Recommendation R083 - Employment Service Recommendation, 1948 (No. 83)
3. Randstad study on the hidden market: https://www.randstad.fr/nos-etudes/
4. Dietz, M., Kubis, A., Leber, U., Müller, A., Stegmaier, J. (2013). Small and medium-sized businesses are competing for skilled workers. Nuremberg: IAB (IAB Short Report 10/2013).
5. European Commission - Issue Paper - Engaging with and Improving Services to Employers - December 2017 - written by Thomas OBERHOLZNER
6. Le recrutement inversé : une approche innovante pour booster le secteur des services à la personne | (in French)France Travail

▶ You can find the other four guides in the "Building my future at work" series on the ILO website:





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